IXIGO TRAINS · PRODUCT CAPSTONE

Best Way to Reach

Turning a waitlisted ticket into a travel plan people trust



Own berth 35% · RAC 25% · Stays WL 40%

Rohit Kumar

Airtribe PM Launchpad · November 2026

Only 1 in 4 waitlisted users leaves with a plan

26%

resolve a booking within 24 hours today

→

42%

target in 6 months

Resolved booking = a confirmed train, bus or flight for the trip, or a waitlisted ticket with a backup or protection the user chose knowingly.

Trains are ixigo’s core, so this moment matters

84.8M

monthly active users, Q4 FY26

104M

train passenger segments booked, FY26

₹511 cr

train revenue, about 42% of the total

85.6%

repeat transaction rate

ixigo, ConfirmTkt and AbhiBus already hold trains, predictions and buses. The gap is not inventory: it is helping users choose between options with confidence.

Source: ixigo FY26 figures from the capstone brief

How I researched it

20

User interviews

20 recorded calls + 1 WhatsApp chat, English and Hindi

7

Survey responses

Bilingual 18-question Google Form; 6 had a recent waitlist

5

Competitors

ixigo, ConfirmTkt, IRCTC VIKALP, MakeMyTrip, redRail

7

Hypotheses

From “can’t compare” to “a 90% chance ends in RAC”

Mix: 10 active ixigo users, 3 who check ixigo but book on IRCTC, 2 who use it less now, 4 IRCTC or MakeMyTrip users, 2 unclear.

What 20 travellers told me

8 of 20

have a personal cut-off

They book a waitlisted ticket only above 80–95% chance. The number is their decision rule.

3 of 20

were let down by high odds

Often got RAC, or a high-chance ticket did not confirm. Same as my own 90% that ended in RAC.

6 of 20

named a different top priority

Comfort, punctuality, speed, safety, timing. One sort order cannot serve them all.

Also heard: 8 named a fallback (flight, bus, Tatkal); 7 book mainly on IRCTC or MakeMyTrip; 2 found login or the flow harder than IRCTC; 3X Refund terms were unclear to several.

21 records: 20 calls + 1 WhatsApp chat; two may be the same person. Counts are qualitative signals, not market share.

Survey: lots of searching, little trust

6 of 6

searched 3+ times before deciding; 2 searched 10+

1.7 / 5

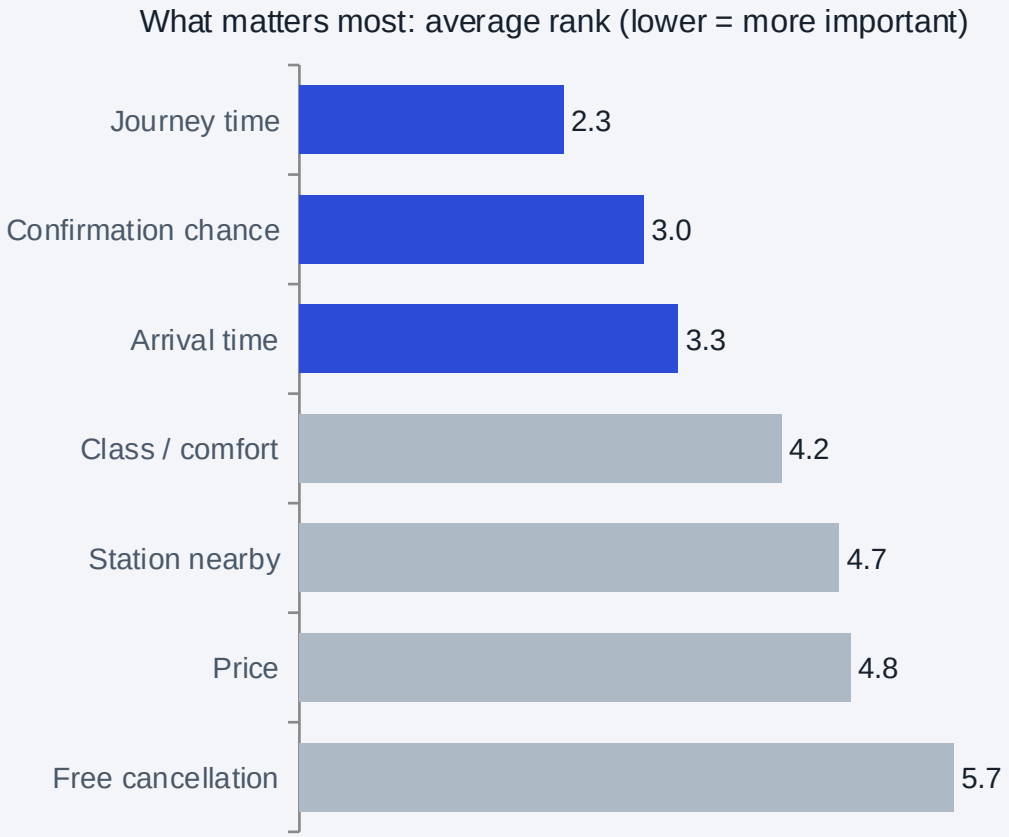
average trust in an app's "% chance"

4 of 6

said the hardest part was too many options or too many apps

2 of 4

who recall a 70%+ ticket saw it end as RAC or stay WL



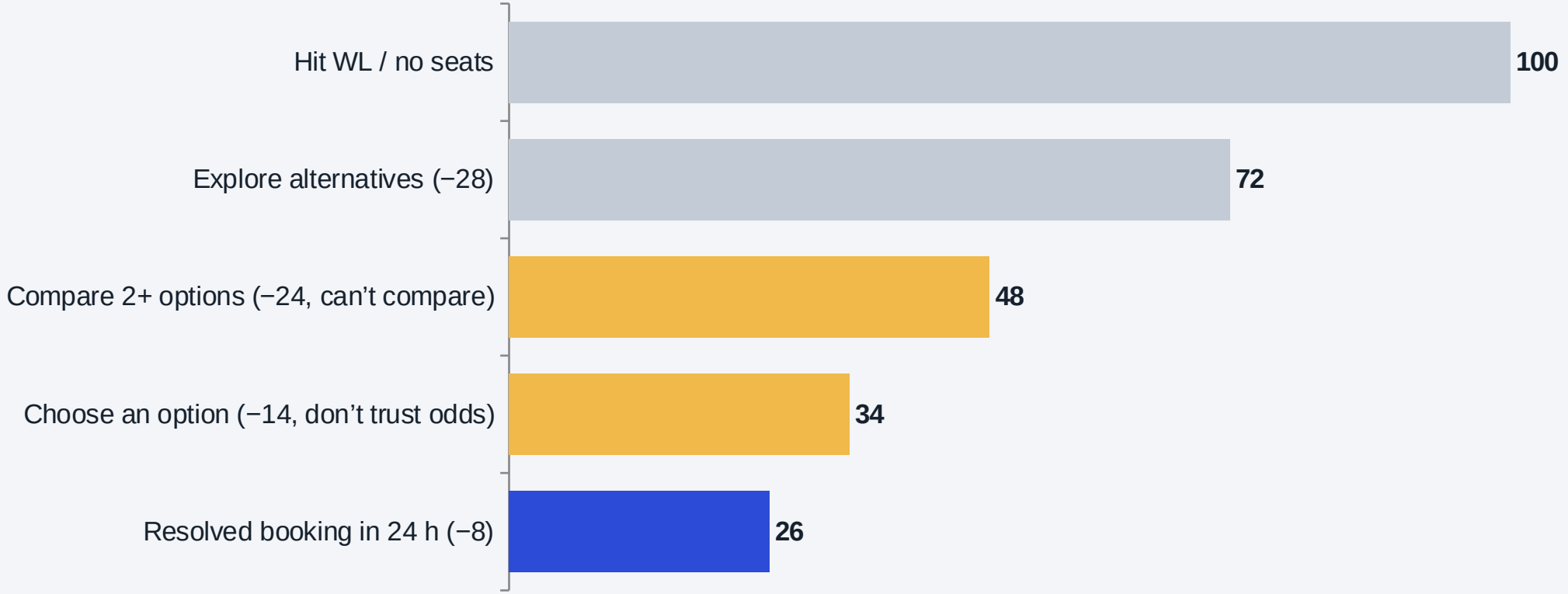
Bilingual Google Form · 7 responses, 6 hit a WL in the last 6 months · small sample, directional only

Everyone sells protection; nobody helps you choose

Player	When the train is waitlisted	Gap for the user
ixigo Trains	Prediction; Alternate Travel Plan (3X / 2X value)	Refund mostly a coupon; user still finds the alternative
ConfirmTkt	Alternates: other quotas, split and train + bus	Many raw options, no ranking
IRCTC VIKALP	Free auto-shift to another train	No choice, outcome known only at chart
MakeMyTrip	Trip Guarantee 3X; route and station hacks	Trade-offs not explained
redRail	Probability; Alternate Trip add-on	Protects money, not the journey
Agents	Tatkal, quota know-how, one answer	Extra cost, no transparency

Opportunity: own the decision moment with a ranked, honest comparison.

Most users drop between exploring and choosing



38 of 100 are lost between exploring and choosing: that is where both solutions act.

Per 100 users. 26% from the brief; middle stages estimated from interviews and the survey.

PRIMARY BARRIER

Users don’t lack options. They lack a way to choose with confidence.

They can’t compare trains, dates, buses and flights in one view, and a single “% confirm” hides whether they’ll get a berth, RAC or nothing.

+16 points is worth about ₹120 crore a year

9.6 lakh

extra resolved bookings a month

₹10 cr

net revenue a month at full rollout

Mode	Extra / month	Net ₹ / booking	₹ cr / month
Train	5,76,000	60	3.5
Bus	2,88,000	110	3.2
Flight	96,000	350	3.4
Total	**9,60,000**		**10.0**

Plus fewer users lost to IRCTC and agents, more cross-mode users, and higher repeat use.

Assumptions: 60 lakh waitlisted users a month; mix 60% train, 30% bus, 10% flight. Estimates, not ixigo data.

The top three of 14 ideas fix the barrier

Idea	Reach	Impact	Conf.	Effort	RICE
Honest outcome meter (CNF / RAC / WL)	60	2	80%	2	**48.0**
Priority chips	60	1	70%	1	**42.0**
Smart compare view	60	3	80%	4	**36.0**
Chart-time decision nudge	40	1	60%	1	24.0
Explainable prediction	60	1	70%	2	21.0
AI trip resolver	60	2	50%	4	15.0
Group-fit filter	20	2	70%	2	14.0

Why these three: they hit the primary barrier head-on. The meter fixes trust; chips and the compare view fix comparison.

Reach = lakh users a month · Effort = person-months · 7 more ideas in the PRD doc

Two solutions, one plan the user believes

A · FIXES COMPARISON

Best Way to Reach

- One ranked list: trains, classes, dates, nearby stations, bus, flight
- Chips plus a “my cut-off” filter, 80% by default
- Top pick with a reason, plus a confirmed backup

Balanced | Arrive by 10 AM | Cheapest

Priority chips re-rank the list

B · FIXES TRUST

Honest Outcome Meter

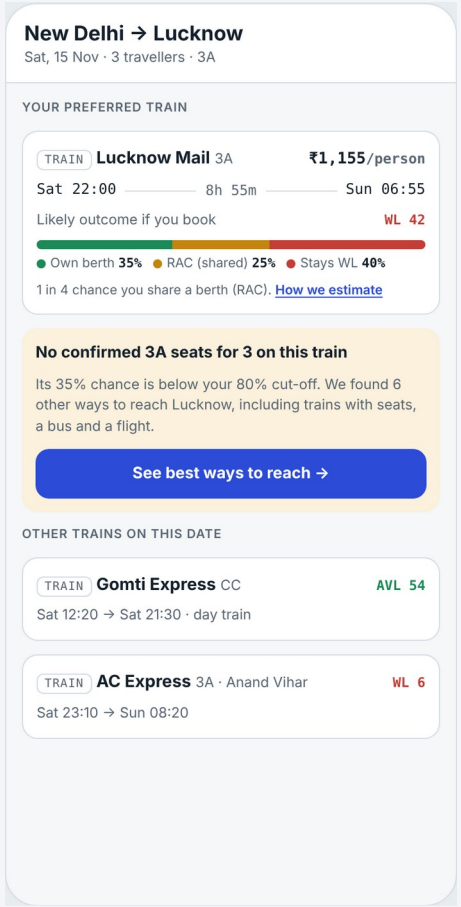
- Own berth / RAC / stays WL instead of one “% confirm”
- “Last 10 similar Saturdays” shows why
- Never says guaranteed; ranges when data is thin



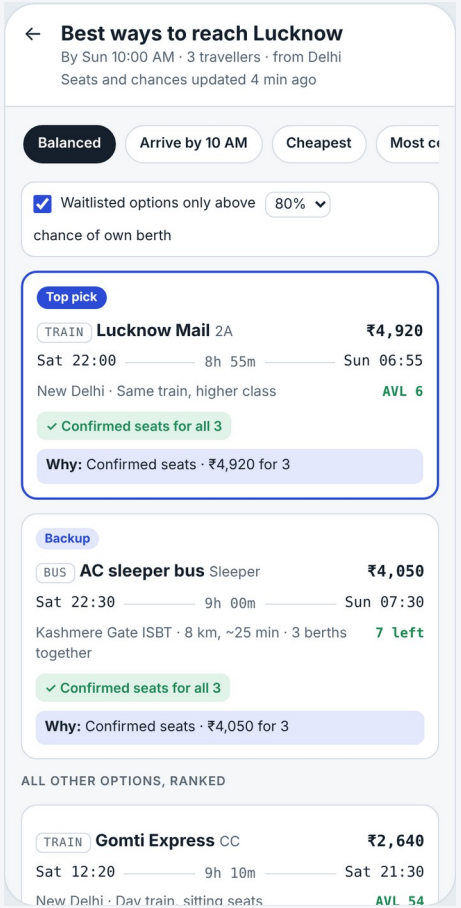
Own berth 55% · RAC 30% · Stays WL 15%

The prototype in four screens

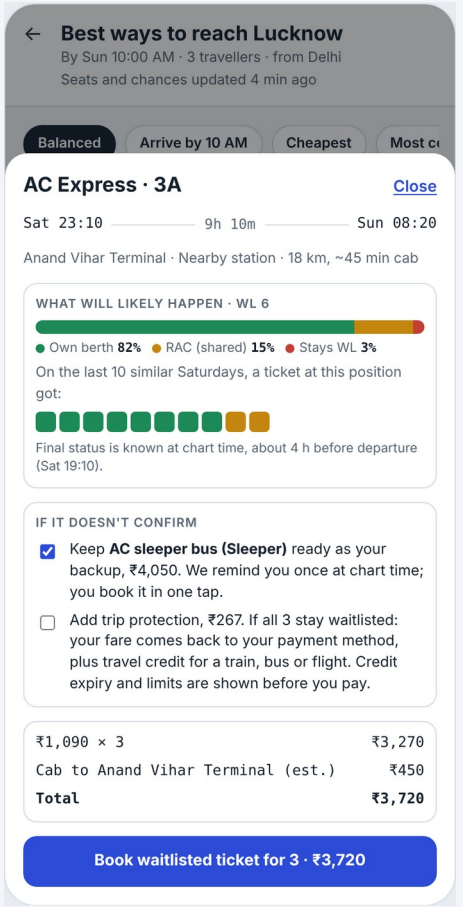
[Live: prototype-rohit-ixigo.lovable.app](prototype-rohit-ixigo.lovable.app)



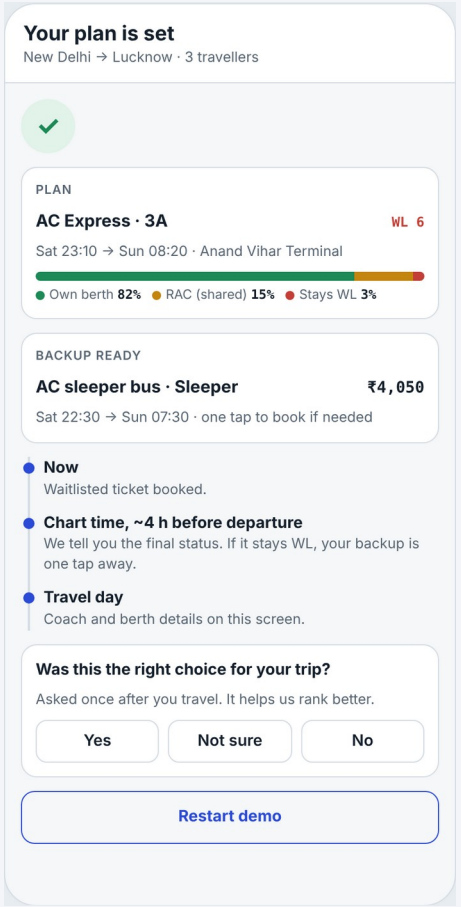
1 · Honest odds



2 · Ranked list



3 · Odds + backup



4 · Plan set

Where the journey changes

Stage	Today	With Best Way to Reach
Sees WL	“40% chance”, is that good?	Own berth 25% · RAC 15% · WL 60%
Explores	Re-searches trains, dates, other apps	One button opens one ranked list
Compares	Notes prices and times in memory	Chips and cut-off re-rank; top pick + backup
Decides	Calls family or agent, or gives up	Books in 2 taps, backup ready
Waits	Checks PNR many times	One chart-time alert
After trip	“The app was wrong” if RAC	“Was this the right choice?”

Launch in the waitlist moment, cohort by cohort

Months 1–2

Pilot

5% of WL users, top 20 routes, A/B test

Next if +4 pts, regret ≤ control

Month 3

Families

Bookings with 3+ passengers

Next if group-fit used by 30%

Months 4–6

All WL users

50% then 100%

Guardrails stable 4 weeks

Then

PNR page

Rescue users already holding WL

10% book a backup

GROWTH LOOP

Hit WL → top pick + backup → trip outcome and regret logged → odds and ranking get sharper → user trusts ixigo first next time and shares the plan on WhatsApp

One North Star, held in check by guardrails

26% → 42% 24-hour resolved booking rate for users who hit WL or no seats

Supporting

- 60% of WL users open Best Way to Reach
- Searches before booking: 3–5 → 1–2
- Time to booking: −40%
- Trust in the shown chance: 1.7 → 3.5

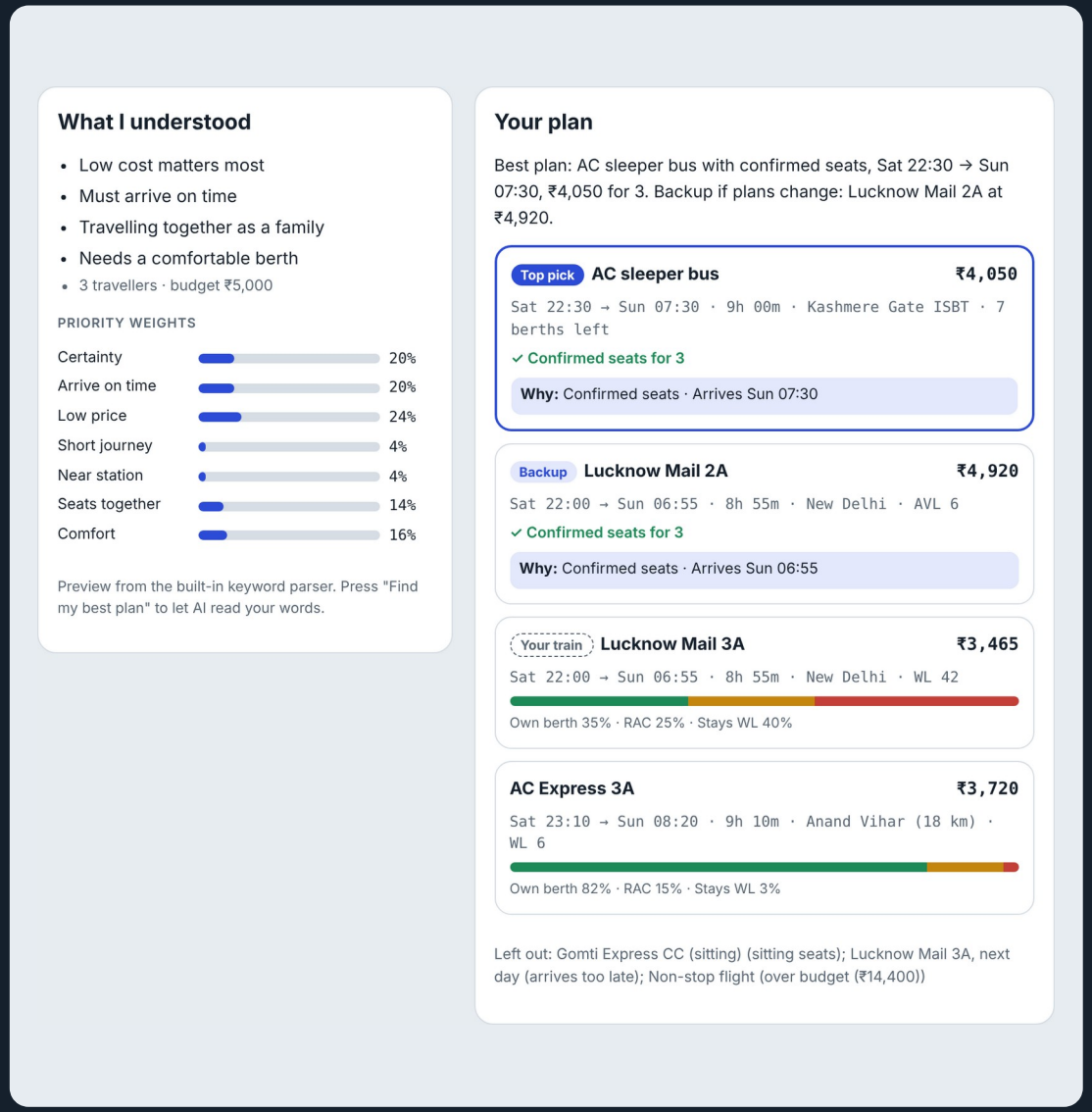
Guardrails

- Regret (“wrong choice”) ≤ 8%
- Predicted vs actual CNF / RAC / WL within 5 pts
- No rise in cancellations of picks
- “Prediction wrong” complaints −30%

Risks we plan for

Risk	Level	Mitigation
Wrong top pick	Medium	Always show a backup; regret tracking
Odds overconfident	Medium	Split + ranges; calibration guardrail
Honest odds cut WL bookings	Medium	Offer protected WL and backup together
Bus or flight data slow	Medium	Show trains first, stream others in
Seen as upselling flights	Low	“Balanced” default; cheapest always visible

Trade-offs we accept: honesty over short-term conversion, a clear recommendation over a neutral list, and speed over full automation in v1.



STEP 8 · AI EXTENSION

Trip Resolver: say it in your own words

- Claude turns “3 of us, mother is 65, reach by Sunday, ₹5,000” into weights and limits
- Transparent code ranks real options; AI never invents trains or prices
- Same honest odds; “guaranteed” is blocked
- Works in Hinglish; keyword fallback if AI is down

From “Is 40% good?” to “I know how I’m getting there.”

Next 2 weeks

Validate RAC-split data with ConfirmTkt; usability test with 5 users

Next 2 months

Pilot on 20 routes, A/B against today’s flow

Next 6 months

All WL users; 42% resolved bookings

Prototype, AI demo, research and PRD: links in the submission · Rohit Kumar